

The Solitaire Tower of Doom

A roguelike solitaire descent through 10 floors of card chaos

The Pitch

You've played Solitaire a thousand times without ever wondering why the shuffle always seems *almost* winnable. **The Solitaire Tower of Doom** answers that question: hidden among the 80 unvigintillion possible arrangements of a 52-card deck is the **Sacred Shuffle** — a configuration that grants dominion over time itself. A secretive cult has spent centuries chasing it by hand. Now, with computers able to deal and reshuffle thousands of games a second, they've found a shortcut: trap an office worker at their desk and make them play, endlessly, until the shuffle appears.

That office worker is you. And you've just been contacted by the ghost of **John Dee** — Elizabethan mathematician, astrologer to Queen Elizabeth I, and the first of your **Time Patrons** — who needs you to beat the cult to it, one floor of the Tower at a time.

It's a familiar, comforting card game wrapped around a roguelike descent, a time-travel conspiracy, and a run-based meta-game players will want to climb again and again.

What It Is

A **browser-based roguelike card game** built on five classic solitaire variants (Klondike, Spider, FreeCell, Pyramid, TriPeaks). Each run is a **10-floor descent**: one solitaire deal per floor, escalating in difficulty, capped by a boss floor. Clear a floor, earn gold and score; run out of lives, and the clock resets — you play again, a little wiser, a little further-progressed.

Genre: Roguelike deck-builder / card puzzle • **Platform:** Web (desktop & mobile browser), zero install • **Comparables:** *Balatro* (score-chasing card roguelike meta-loop) × classic Windows Solitaire (universal, nostalgic ruleset) × *Slay the Spire* (run structure, shops, permadeath tension)

Core Loop

1. **Descend** — Pick a floor on the Tower map; each floor is a fresh shuffle of a solitaire variant, harder the deeper you go.
2. **Play** — Standard solitaire rules, but every move is scored (waste → tableau, reveals, foundation plays), building toward a 1,040-point “perfect game” per deal.
3. **Shop** — Spend gold between floors on occult relics — the Scrying Glass (hints), the Athame (delete a card), the Enochian Key (draw from anywhere in the stock) — each a reskinned solitaire “cheat” with real strategic weight.
4. **Survive** — Three lives per run. Undo too much, misplay a boss floor, and you lose one. Zero lives ends the run — but not the story.
5. **Ascend the meta** — Persistent currency, unlockable cardbacks, and a **Compendium** of Time Patrons (John Dee, Mary Queen of Scots, and more) whose historical ties to card games and the occult unlock across runs, deepening the lore with every attempt.

The Hook: Why a Card Game Needs a Story

Solitaire is the most-played video game in human history and has never once had a narrative. *The Solitaire Tower of Doom* gives it one — noir-conspiracy dialogue delivered between floors, breaking the fourth wall (“you feel strangely compelled to keep looking at your screen”) and escalating into a genuinely funny, genuinely eerie pitch: what if the reason Solitaire is so compulsively replayable is that *something* wants you to keep shuffling? The Time Patrons vs. the Cult of Patience (“I call them the Cult of Doom”) gives every run emotional stakes without ever slowing down the card-game core.

Key Features

Feature	Why it matters
5 solitaire variants, 1 unified scoring system	Broad appeal to every solitaire fan, not just Klondike purists
Roguelike run structure with permadeath	Every session is disposable and replayable — “one more run” design
Relic shop with 19+ items across 4 tiers	Meaningful build variety without changing the underlying card rules
Boss floors	Clear stakes and pacing beats within a 10-floor run
Time Patron narrative + Compendium	A reason to keep playing beyond the score — unlockable lore, portraits, cardbacks
No install, no account required to start	Instant, frictionless web play; ideal for viral/organic discovery

Art & Tone

Gilded, candlelit occult-Victoriana: gold filigree UI, wax-seal iconography, portraits of real historical figures reframed as secret keepers of the Sacred Shuffle. Tone splits the difference between *Hades*’ mythic-cast-of-characters structure and the dry, deadpan comedy of finding out your office job is a centuries-old magic ritual.

Why It Works

- **Zero learning curve, infinite hook** — everyone already knows how to play Solitaire; the roguelike shell and story are pure upside.
- **Session flexibility** — a single floor takes 2–5 minutes; a full run is a lunch break; the meta-progression rewards returning daily.
- **Built-in nostalgia + built-in novelty** — leans on the most familiar card game on Earth while making it feel unplayed for the first time.

Status

Playable web build live today at solitairetower (Klondike, Spider, FreeCell, Pyramid, TriPeaks fully implemented; shop, scoring, floor map, and Act One of the John Dee narrative shipped). Next: expand the Time Patron roster (Mary, Queen of Scots in development), additional relics, and boss-floor set-pieces.